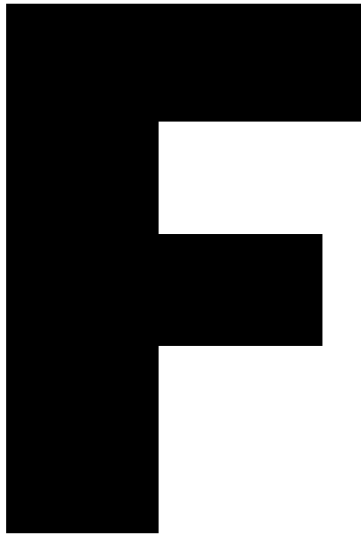




FIVE YEARS IS not a very long time. But neither is it too short. It's roughly the same time span in which a teenage child transforms into an adult or certain trees take to mature and bear fruit. For democracies too, five years means new governments, new policies and economic cycles.

42 | The same holds true for India. As the fastest-growing major economy in the world—with an estimated growth rate of more than 7% over two straight years—it has ambitions of turning into a \$5-trillion economy over the next few years. But it has to address a number of challenges—from sustaining economic growth through more policy reforms, creation of adequate physical infrastructure, boosting private sector investments, meeting the health and nutritional needs of a growing population, finding adequate jobs for its workforce, and mitigating the risks of climate change.

Meanwhile, the global geopolitical landscape is in for a reset with national elections in as many as 50 countries this year. According to US-based think tank Integrity Institute, in 2024, as many as 83 elections (national or otherwise) are being held across 78 countries; this means these polls would impact the lives of nearly half the world's population who collectively reside there. “We won’t see that many again until 2048. What also makes 2024 special is not just the number of countries but the fact that for the first time, you will have a US presidential election in the same year as elections in major countries such as India, Indonesia, Ukraine, Taiwan, Mexico, the UK, and the European Parliament,” it noted. (*See graphic ‘Poll Fever’*)

What India will be in 2029 will in a large part be shaped by the next government that comes to power after the General Elections this year; the new government will lay down the key priorities for the next five years as well as the policy prescriptions that are required.

A BRIGHT SPOT

The India story continues to be a bright spot for the international community, which is yet to fully recover from the impact of the pandemic, as well as the two ongoing wars and the Red Sea conflict. (*See graphic ‘Shining Bright’*)

According to Christian de Guzman, Senior Vice President at Moody’s

POLL FEVER

- Elections in over 50 countries this year will change the geopolitical landscape
- India and the US are set to hold national elections this year

(TOTAL NUMBER OF ELECTIONS BY REGION)

Region	Elections
Europe	20
Rest of Africa	18
North America	9
Asia	7
Middle East	4
Oceania	3
South America	2
North Africa	2
SOURCE INTEGRITY INSTITUTE	

DATA AS OF MARCH 10, 2023

Investors Service, the agency expects India to be one of the fastest-growing—if not the fastest—G20 economies over the next five years, largely based on its ability to weather the lacklustre near-term outlook for global growth due to its large consumption-based economy, boosted by the government’s efforts to improve productivity via reforms and infrastructure development. “Over the longer-term, India also stands to benefit from favourable demographics in contrast to the ageing populations in other large economies, including China. At the same time, this relatively favourable view assumes that India will sustain broad financial stability and gradual fiscal consolidation—areas that have previously weighed on the country’s potential growth and